

WHEN SEVA AND PROFESSIONAL RESPONSIBILITY MEET: A CAREGIVER'S OBSERVATION OF LIFE, DUTY AND RESPONSIBILITY

There is a difficult reality that becomes visible when a person tries to carry two demanding responsibilities simultaneously: professional work and round-the-clock seva (service and caregiving). When one person is solely responsible for the lives and welfare of dependent beings, one responsibility inevitably competes for time, attention and presence with the other. This is particularly true in the life of a single caretaker or a single parent.

I am not presenting this merely as a theory. I am describing an observation drawn from my own life and experience.

I was working as an engineer in my last project inside NTPC Barh. Alongside my professional responsibilities, I gradually found myself running a rescue centre—BARH ANIMAL RESCUE CENTER—not because I had originally planned to establish one, but because circumstances, compassion and the demands of helpless lives compelled me to do so. Today, 21 rescued dogs are dependent upon me.

MY OBSERVATIONS

1. WATER, HYGIENE AND HEALTH

During my absence, I observed that two or three dogs sometimes urinated in their own water pot and later drank from it. Such behaviour can create serious hygiene concerns and may increase the risk of illness. When a caregiver is physically present, such situations can be noticed and corrected immediately; in the caregiver's absence, they may remain unnoticed.

2. FIGHTING AND INJURIES

During the mating season, the dogs sometimes fought with considerable violence and aggression. On returning from work, I found some of them wounded. Managing such situations requires continuous observation, timely intervention and, when necessary, separation and medical attention.

3. UNEQUAL ACCESS TO FOOD

Another difficulty arises during feeding. A stronger or more dominant dog may consume the food kept for another dog who did not eat at its usual feeding time. Consequently, a timid or weaker dog may repeatedly miss meals and gradually become thin and physically weak. Fair feeding therefore requires supervision, not merely placing food before them.

4. OUTSIDE INTERFERENCE AND DELIBERATE DISTURBANCE

At times, outsiders have interfered with the rescued dogs in disturbing and potentially dangerous ways. I have witnessed or encountered acts such as:

- throwing stones at them;
- throwing a poisoned dead rat;
- intentionally offering spoiled or foul-smelling food;
- creating openings or pathways through which the dogs might escape or run away; and
- deliberately provoking or creating fights among them.

A rescue centre is not merely a place where animals are kept. It is a place where vulnerable lives are entrusted to human responsibility. Any deliberate interference can therefore become a matter



of life and death.

5. HOWLING, NEIGHBOURHOOD DISTURBANCE AND SOCIAL PRESSURE

When I remain away for a long period because of work, the dogs sometimes howl. Neighbours and nearby shopkeepers become disturbed and understandably express their discomfort. I have therefore been asked, sometimes quite rudely, to move the dogs elsewhere.

Yet there is a striking difference when I am physically present. They become calm, disciplined and obedient. Even a person who does not know the centre might find it difficult to imagine that 21 rescued dogs are living there.

MY CONCLUSION

Through this experience, I have come to understand that seva in the form of rescue and caregiving is not simply a charitable activity that can be performed in spare time. It is, in many respects, a 24-hour responsibility.

If all the rescued animals are healthy, stable and free from immediate danger, a caretaker may sometimes find enough flexibility to attend to personal or professional commitments. But when even one animal becomes seriously ill, injured, frightened or vulnerable, the situation changes completely. The caregiver's personal and professional life can suddenly be reshaped around that life that cannot speak for itself.

This is the paradox of genuine seva: the person who chooses to protect a dependent life also accepts a responsibility that does not follow office hours.

I have also learned something deeper. Some people seem to be naturally drawn towards caregiving and rescue work. They feel the suffering of vulnerable beings deeply and instinctively step forward when others walk away. In my experience, this calling is not always something that can be taught through training or imposed through education. Skills can certainly be learned, knowledge can certainly be acquired, and discipline can certainly be developed—but the inner impulse to stand beside a helpless life often comes from somewhere deeper within a person.

A ground-level social worker, rescuer or caregiver therefore does not merely manage animals, people or situations. Such a person often carries their fear, pain, vulnerability and survival in his or her own heart.

For this reason, society should understand that sustained seva requires more than goodwill. It requires time, physical presence, financial stability, emotional strength, safe space and a practical structure that allows the caregiver to continue serving without sacrificing every other responsibility of life.

My experience at BARH ANIMAL RESCUE CENTER has taught me that compassion without practical support can eventually become an impossible burden. But compassion supported by a sustainable system can become a lasting service to life.

This is not a complaint against responsibility. It is an appeal to understand the true nature of responsibility.

When a person becomes the guardian of lives that cannot protect themselves, giving them safety is no longer a part-time act of kindness. It becomes a commitment.

